

COLLECTION · BUYERS

The 5 Mistakes That Cost Buyers \$10,000

*Costly first-purchase traps — and how to avoid
them*

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

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Edition

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Costly first-purchase traps — and how to avoid them

Buying a property is exciting. But a few classic, almost always avoidable mistakes can cost you thousands of dollars — sometimes ten thousand and more. The good news: they're known, predictable, and this guide shows you exactly how to sidestep them.

Each chapter breaks down a frequent mistake: why people make it, what it costs, and the simple reflex that protects you. At the end, an action plan and a quiz to anchor it all.

Use the “My notes” section after each chapter to spot whether you're at risk... and correct course before it's too late.

This guide reads fast and stays within reach: each mistake fits on one page, with the reflex that avoids it. Read it through once, then come back to it at each stage of your purchase — from pre-approval to signing at the notary.

The amounts quoted are orders of magnitude (2026 edition): always confirm the exact figures with your broker, your mortgage broker and your notary, as they vary by property, municipality and your situation.

CHAPTER

Mistake #1 — Shopping without a real pre-approval

Understanding why buying without a solid pre-approval leads to overpaying or disappointment.

The mistake: visiting properties, falling in love, then discovering that the financing doesn't follow — or worse, committing beyond your means. Without a pre-approval, you know neither your real amount, nor your guaranteed rate, nor your room to maneuver.

What it costs

- A crush lost to a pre-approved buyer (in a fast market).
- A purchase above your real capacity, revealed too late, with suffocating payments.
- Weeks wasted visiting in the wrong price range.

The reflex that protects you

Get a pre-approval (a confirmed amount + a rate guaranteed 90 to 120 days) BEFORE shopping. Remember that the lender qualifies your file at a “qualifying” rate higher than the actual rate (the stress test): the amount may be more conservative than hoped, but it's your safety ceiling.

Concretely, a pre-approval checks your income, your debts and your credit, and guarantees a rate for a period (often 90 to 120 days). It's that document — not an estimate over the phone — that makes you a credible buyer and protects you if rates rise during your search.

EMILIE'S TIP

Pre-approval isn't paperwork: it's your negotiating power. A seller almost always chooses the offer with the most solid financing, at equal price.

CHAPTER

Mistake #2 — Underestimating the “invisible” costs

Budgeting all the buying costs, not just the down payment and the mortgage.

The mistake: calculating the down payment and the monthly payment, then getting surprised by a pile of very real fees. Added up, they often exceed \$10,000.

The fees to plan for

- Welcome Tax (transfer duties): a few thousand dollars, payable after the purchase.
- Notary fees.
- Pre-purchase inspection and, if needed, specialized expert assessments.
- Adjustments at the notary (taxes already paid by the seller, heating oil, condo).
- Home insurance, moving, first repairs and a maintenance reserve (~1%/year of the value).

None of these items is optional or surprising in itself: it's forgetting them that costs a lot, in stress and last-minute credit-card debt.

On a \$450,000 purchase, add up the Welcome Tax, notary, inspection, adjustments and insurance: the bill often exceeds \$10,000, to be paid on top of the down payment. Also plan a cushion for the first months (small repairs, furnishing) and keep a written estimate of your fees before making an offer.

EMILIE'S TIP

As soon as you're pre-approved, ask for a written estimate of ALL the closing costs for your price range, Welcome Tax included. You budget the whole purchase, not just the entry.

CHAPTER

Mistake #3 — Rushing (or skipping) the inspection

Making the inspection a real protection, not a formality.

The mistake: giving up the inspection to make your offer more “attractive” in a tight market, or choosing the first inspector who comes along without reading their report. An undetected structural defect — foundation, roof, drain, pyrite — can cost tens of thousands of dollars.

The reflex that protects you

- Make the promise to purchase conditional on an inspection by a recognized professional.
- Go along with the inspector and ask questions; read the report in full.
- In Quebec, watch the local points: clay soils, pyrite/pyrrhotite, French drain, buried tank, vermiculite.

A detected problem becomes leverage: renegotiate the price, demand fixes, or withdraw. That's exactly what the inspection condition allows.

A good inspection covers the structure, the roof, the envelope, the plumbing, the electrical and the signs of water. In Quebec, stay attentive to the regional issues — pyrite, clay soils, French drain, buried tank — depending on the area and the building's age. A detected defect also becomes negotiating leverage, not just a hurdle.

EMILIE'S TIP

Never give up the inspection just to “win” an offer. The house you land without an inspection can become the most expensive of your life.

CHAPTER

Mistake #4 — Letting emotion drive the offer

Keeping a cool head, especially in a multiple-offer situation.

The mistake: overbidding on emotion, dropping conditions out of fear of losing, or exceeding your limit “just this once”. In a multiple-offer market, adrenaline pushes you to pay too much for the wrong reason.

The reflex that protects you

- Set your absolute maximum price in advance — the one you're comfortable with, not just your pre-approval.
- Offer from a comparative analysis (recent similar sales), not from a feeling.
- Remember there will be other properties: none is so unique as to ruin your plan.

A “clean” offer (reasonable conditions, dates suited to the seller, solid financing) often wins without being the highest.

Discipline beats adrenaline: decide in advance on your ceiling price AND the conditions you refuse to drop (inspection, financing). A clean, well-financed offer often reassures the seller as much as one more dollar — and spares you the regret of overpaying on emotion.

EMILIE'S TIP

Write your ceiling price on a piece of paper before the negotiation, and commit to not exceeding it. Tomorrow's “you” will thank you.

CHAPTER

Mistake #5 — Neglecting the neighbourhood, resale and documents

Thinking beyond the crush: location, future value and document checks.

The mistake: buying for the décor and forgetting what really weighs on value — the location, the resale, and (for a condo) the co-ownership's financial health.

The reflex that protects you

- Assess the neighbourhood like an investment: transit, schools, services, noise, projects, resale.
- For a condo, examine the declaration of co-ownership, the contingency fund, the budget and the meeting minutes: an under-funded fund heralds special assessments.
- Have the location certificate and the seller's declaration examined before finalizing.

You can never renovate a location or a neighbourhood: those are what protect your stake on resale day.

The crush fades, the location remains: a well-served neighbourhood resells better and protects your stake. For a condo, the co-ownership's financial health (contingency fund, budget, meeting minutes) weighs as much as the unit. Read all the documents before fulfilling your conditions.

EMILIE'S TIP

Always ask yourself about resale on buying day. What holds you back today (a busy street, a poorly managed condo) will also hold back your future buyer.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. Check that I have an up-to-date pre-approval.
2. Get a written estimate of my total closing costs.

Within 30 days

1. Choose a recognized inspector and plan for the inspection condition.
2. Write my absolute ceiling price and my list of neighbourhood criteria.

Next

1. Book a free consultation with Emilie to validate my offer strategy.

Before signing

1. Re-read the promise to purchase and confirm in writing that all my conditions are fulfilled.
2. Confirm the exact amount to bring to the notary.

On the big day

1. Do a final (pre-closing) visit to check the condition of the premises.
2. Have my ID and my proof of home insurance in force ready.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Pre-approval: a confirmed amount + a guaranteed rate, often 90 to 120 days.
- Closing costs: Welcome Tax, notary, inspection, adjustments, insurance.
- Inspection condition: a way out and a negotiating lever.
- Contingency fund: a co-ownership's collective savings for major work.
- Comparative analysis: recent sales of similar properties used to set the price.
- Welcome Tax: transfer duties billed by the municipality after the purchase.
- Adjustments: pro-rata split of the taxes and fees already paid by the seller.
- Multiple offers: several buyers submit at the same time; set your ceiling in advance.
- Latent defect: a non-apparent defect making the property unfit for its use.
- Counter-offer: the seller's reply modifying a term of your offer.
- Down payment: the part of the price paid in cash, outside mortgage financing.
- Pre-approval: a confirmed amount and a guaranteed rate, valid for a limited period.

GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. The best protection against overpaying is:

- A) Visiting lots of houses
- B) A solid pre-approval before shopping
- C) Always offering the asking price
- D) Avoiding brokers

2. The “invisible” fees of a purchase can easily exceed:

- A) \$100
- B) \$1,000
- C) \$10,000
- D) Nothing, it's all in the mortgage

3. Giving up the inspection to “win” an offer is risky because:

- A) It's illegal
- B) An undetected latent defect can be very costly
- C) The notary requires it
- D) It has no impact

4. In a multiple-offer situation, you mainly need to:

- A) Drop all your conditions
- B) Exceed your budget to win
- C) Set a ceiling price in advance and stick to it
- D) Offer at random

5. A “clean” offer is an offer:

- A) Always the highest
- B) With no conditions at all
- C) With reasonable conditions, suitable dates and solid financing
- D) Made without a broker

6. For a condo, an essential document to examine is:

- A) The neighbouring restaurant's menu
- B) The contingency fund and the meeting minutes
- C) The colour of the walls
- D) Nothing in particular

7. What you can never renovate is:

- A) The kitchen
- B) The location and the neighbourhood
- C) The bathroom
- D) The cladding

8. The Welcome Tax is paid:

- A) Before the offer
- B) Every month with the mortgage
- C) After the purchase, in a single municipal payment
- D) Never

9. The offer price should rest on:

- A) The emotion of the moment
- B) A comparative analysis of recent sales
- C) The asking price, always
- D) The neighbours' opinion

10. The recommended maintenance reserve is about:

- A) 0%
- B) 1% of the value per year
- C) 10% per month
- D) 50% at purchase

11. The inspection condition notably lets you:

- A) Change notaries
- B) Renegotiate, demand fixes or withdraw
- C) Avoid the Welcome Tax
- D) Cancel the mortgage

Answer key

1. **B** — Pre-approval sets your ceiling and makes your offers credible (mistake #1).
2. **C** — Welcome Tax, notary, inspection, adjustments, insurance add up (mistake #2).
3. **B** — The inspection is your protection against structural defects (mistake #3).

4. **C** — You decide your limit with a cool head so you don't overbid on emotion (mistake #4).
5. **C** — It reassures the seller as much as the amount (mistake #4).
6. **B** — An under-funded fund heralds special assessments (mistake #5).
7. **B** — Location largely determines value and resale (mistake #5).
8. **C** — It's a municipal transfer duty payable after the transaction (mistake #2).
9. **B** — Comparables give a rational basis (mistake #4).
10. **B** — About 1%/year covers roof, furnace, water heater, etc. (mistake #2).
11. **B** — It's real leverage if a problem is detected (mistake #3).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

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